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## 18-YEAR-OLD POOJA WON GOLD IN THE WOMEN'S HIGH JUMP WITH A CLEARANCE OF 1.84M, ERASING THE PREVIOUS MEET RECORD OF 1.83M SET BY SWAPNA BARMAN IN 2022

### Next generation

India's next generation wasn't just making a mark on the shooting range. Sixteen-year-old Suryaksh Rawat was praised by double Olympic medallist PV Sindhu after reaching the final of the badminton men's singles category. Fourteen-year-old Olympian Dhinidhi Desinghu of Karnataka set new

national records in the women's 400m and 200m freestyle categories, picking up 11 medals, including nine golds. But while Dhinidhi's medal haul in the pool in Haldwani might overshadow some of the other participants, perhaps the most promising prospect of the Games emerged at the weightlifting hall in Dehradun.

Gyaneshwari Yadav delivered a striking performance, lifting a total of 192kg in the women's 49kg category, which, along with her snatch (85kg), was more than what any other Indian weightlifter apart from Mirabai had lifted in that division. It was also more than what Mirabai was lifting at the same age.

Records were also set by Bindyarani Devi in the women's 55kg category (snatch lift of 88kg), Mehak Sharma (snatch 106kg, clean and jerk 141kg, and total 247kg) in the women's 87+ kg category, Vaishnav Thakur in the men's 102kg category (160kg snatch), and Rudra Mayan (175kg snatch) in the men's 109+ kg category.

The National Games' odd timing actually adds to the significance of these results. Coming at a time in the season when they are still some way from their best, India's athletes will only improve as the season progresses. Indeed, even where some athletes fell short of national marks, there was enough in their results in Uttarakhand to hint at interesting matchups in the years going forward.

18-year-old Haryana athlete Pooja improved on her personal best and meet record, winning gold in the women's high jump with a clearance of 1.84m, erasing the previous meet record of 1.83m set by Swapna Barman in 2022. But Pooja, like Swapna, has her sights set on the women's heptathlon going forward. A high jump like the one she uncorked in Dehradun should boost her points total significantly. But she is unlikely to go unchallenged.

Moumita Mondal of West Bengal didn't set any records but made a major improvement in her 100m hurdles while also winning gold in the women's long jump, happening almost simultaneously. Moumita has also given the heptathlon a shot in recent times, and both she and Pooja will be tempted to give the event a go once again with the Asian Games coming next season.